



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: St. Mary Catholic Classical School

School Website: <https://www.stmaryschoolwilliamston.com/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

St Mary Catholic Classical School Williamston (MI 48895) demonstrates a coherent blend of Catholic religious formation with classical curricular elements. The public-facing materials emphasize faith-informed formation, unity of faith and reason, virtue, and liturgical life, while also presenting a clear grammar-logic-rhetoric progression and a commitment to classical formation. The strongest evidence supports CLASSICAL at the Religious & Metaphysical Foundations and School Purpose & Goal categories, as well as substantial alignment in Curriculum and Community engagement. Pedagogy and Faculty show meaningful classical markers (e.g., memory-driven lower-elementary pedagogy and rhetoric-focused upper grades), but explicit wording about the faculty as a living curriculum and about Socratic seminars or formal faculty portraits is less evident in the public materials. Overall, the school sits firmly within the Classical tradition in key areas but does not consistently surface every hallmark in every category in its public communications. Aggregate assessment: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

- Executive highlights by category:
- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: CLASSICAL. Strong emphasis on faith formation, liturgical life, and theology integrated with schooling. Evidence includes Daily Mass, core pillars (Education in Virtue, Classical Formation, Christian Discipleship), and explicit Theology/CGS content.
- Purpose and Goal: CLASSICAL. Formation, virtue, and the pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty foreground the mission; explicit statements about unity of faith and reason and virtue formation.
- Curriculum: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. Grammar, Logic, and Rhetoric are present (grammar-stage/logic-stage/rhetoric-stage language in materials); history is present; Great Books/Great Conversation is not explicitly named in public materials.
- Pedagogy: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. Contemplative/restful elements and memory-based lower-school practices are evident (singing, chanting, memory); upper-school rhetoric training is present; explicit Socratic/seminar pedagogy is not clearly documented in public pages.
- Faculty: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. Foundational emphasis on virtue and formation is clear; explicit “living curriculum” or faculty portraits are not prominently documented in the public materials.
- Parents & Community: CLASSICAL. Pronounced partnership with parents (parents as first teachers; Prime Time family formation program; open-campus/visits) is strongly evidenced.
- What would move the needle (for SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL statuses):
- More explicit articulation of Great Books/Great Conversation and Socratic seminars in high school (or explicit rationale for their absence in 9–12 if applicable).
- Clear statements about the living curriculum and faculty professional formation as classical tutors, including portraits or faculty profiles.
- Additional emphasis on a historical timeline across the curriculum that foregrounds Western civilization in canonical terms.
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ABSTRACT: See below for the concise synthesis and category-by-category breakdown.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — [CLASSICAL]

Evidence

- Mission emphasizes faith-informed formation: “unifying faith and reason to carry the light of truth to the world” and “imitate the virtues of Jesus Christ.”
- Daily Mass for 1st–8th grades and frequent opportunities for reconciliation.
- Core pillars include Education in Virtue, Classical Formation, Christian Discipleship, and Joyful Fidelity to the Catholic Church.
- The Theology of the Body and CGS are integrated into the program, signaling explicit theological engagement.
- The school explicitly frames education as formation in virtue and truth, with references to unity of faith and reason and cultivation of virtue.

Positive Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords aligned with the document’s lexicon include: truth, beauty, virtue, theology, liturgy, Mass, sacred, worship; references to a sacramental worldview and sacred tradition appear via Catholic identity. The Six Elements lexicon codifies these as core indicators of Classical religious foundations.
- The site explicitly mentions “Truth and Beauty” as goods in themselves and emphasizes theology and liturgical life.

Why this rating

- The school’s public materials foreground transcendental moral realism through faith-based formation, explicit theology integration, liturgical life (Daily Mass, reconciliation), and worship practices. This mirrors the Positive keyword indicators for Religious & Metaphysical Foundations. The absence of negative indicators in this category further reinforces CLASSICAL alignment.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — [CLASSICAL]

Evidence

- Mission statements frame education as formation and the cultivation of virtue and wisdom, not merely job preparation.
- The school emphasizes uniting faith and reason, and the pursuit of truth, beauty, and virtue in the student experience.
- Public materials state graduates are “grounded in the unity of faith and reason,” with an emphasis on reading, speaking, and thinking well, and that “truth and beauty are good in themselves.”

Positive Keyword Analysis

- Positive indicators include formation, virtue, human flourishing, pursuit of the true/good/beautiful, and scholé-like contemplation. The Six Elements document maps these as core signals of Classical education.
- Explicit phrasing about truth, goodness, and beauty as real and knowable appears in mission materials.

Why this rating

- The school consistently articulates formation and virtue as central aims, aligning with the Classical emphasis on formation over mere information, and on pursuing transcendentals (truth, goodness, beauty). The absence of explicit programmatic emphasis on “workforce preparation” in the public content supports CLASSICAL.

Element 3: School Curriculum — [SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL]

Evidence

- Liberal arts are represented by Grammar, Logic, and Rhetoric through named stages (Grammar Stage, Logic Stage, Rhetoric Stage). This is visible in materials describing the progression through the Trivium.
- History appears across the curriculum, with references to historical dates and interdisciplinary study in the grammar stage materials.
- The program includes Disciple in Christ, CGS, Theology of the Body, and other Catholic formation elements, indicating integrated content beyond secular core subjects.

Positive Keyword Analysis

- Positive signals include: grammar, logic, rhetoric; Great Books / Great Conversation is not explicitly named in public pages; history across the curriculum; wonder/formation. The lexicon identifies grammar/logic/rhetoric as core liberal arts and “Great Books” as a hallmark if present. Here, grammar/logic/rhetoric are present, but Great Books is not explicitly named.
- History and the integration of wonder align with the positive indicators for Curriculum (though not all Great Books language is shown).

Why this rating

- The presence of the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and history integration strongly aligns with classical curriculum expectations; however, explicit Great Books / Great Conversation language is not surfaced in public materials, which moderates the overall rating to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — [SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL]

Evidence

- Lower-school pedagogy features memory-based, singing/chanting, and restfulness elements (scholé-like approach) in the grammar-stage framing.
- Upper-school pedagogy includes a rhetoric-focused trajectory (Rhetoric Stage: “learn to express themselves with fluency, grace and persuasiveness”).
- The presence of CGS and Disciple-in-Christ approaches signals integration of contemplative, virtue-centered pedagogy and liturgical/life-forming practices.

Positive Keyword Analysis

- Positive indicators include contemplative/restful learning (scholé), memory work, singing/chanting, narration/recitation, rhetoric, and liturgical calendar integration. The Six Elements lexicon lists these patterns as classical pedagogy signals.
- The site’s public materials explicitly describe singing/memory in lower grades and a strong rhetoric focus in upper grades, consistent with classical pedagogy patterns.

Why this rating

- Pedagogical signals are present (restful and contemplative lower grades, memory-based pedagogy; rhetoric in upper grades). However, explicit references to Socratic seminars or formal seminars is not clearly documented in the public content. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL classification rather than CLASSICAL.

Element 5: School Faculty — [SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL]

Evidence

- The public materials foreground virtue-based formation and “classical formation,” but there is less explicit language about teachers as the living curriculum or a formal faculty portrait. The site highlights

the role of teachers as guides within a virtue-centered framework but does not consistently publish a faculty profile or “living curriculum” language in public pages.

- The Catholic formation and partner model imply a teacher-student mentor relationship, yet explicit statements about faculty as the “living curriculum” or a formal faculty culture are not prominently surfaced in the available pages.

Positive Keyword Analysis

- Positive indicators (from the Six Elements lexicon) would include: model teachers and mentors, living curriculum, portrait of teacher/student ideals, collegiality, and virtue exemplars. The site emphasizes virtue and formation roles but does not consistently surface explicit “living curriculum” or portraits.
- There is some alignment with virtue-centered teacher roles and mentorship implied in program descriptions (e.g., Disciple in Christ, Education in Virtue).

Why this rating

- While strong alignment exists in terms of the teacher’s role in virtue and formation, the lack of explicit public-facing statements about teachers as the living curriculum or a formal faculty portrait pushes Element 5 toward SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — [CLASSICAL]

Evidence

- The site states: “parents are the child’s first teachers,” and emphasizes partnership with families. It also references initiatives like Prime Time (Continuing Education for Primary Educators) to support parental formation and a community-wide approach to classical education.
- There are explicit calls for parent involvement, open campus policies, and opportunities for family participation (CGS/Catechesis of the Good Shepherd, TOB-related content, and content around family life).
- “Disciple in Christ” and “Education in Virtue” emphasize forming families, not just students, aligning with classical norms of parental partnership and formation.

Positive Keyword Analysis

- Positive indicators include: partnership with parents, parental formation, open campus, family liturgy alignment, and parents as co-teachers. These map to the Six Elements’ Parents & Community positive keywords.
- The site explicitly signals parental leadership in education (e.g., “parents are the child’s first teachers,” “Prime Time” as continuing education for families).

Why this rating

- The public materials show robust and explicit engagement with parents as co-teachers and a community-education loop, consistent with CLASSICAL signals for Parents & Community.

What Would Move the Needle

- If the school wants to move Element 3 (Curriculum) from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL to CLASSICAL, it should explicitly publish and emphasize Great Books/Great Conversation, and provide a public rationale for how Great Books are integrated or why the approach differs in this Catholic classical environment.
- To strengthen Element 4 (Pedagogy), the school could add clear statements about Socratic seminars, seminars, or structured Socratic dialogue in upper grades, and how memory work and rhetorical practice are integrated with disciplined inquiry.
- For Element 5 (Faculty), publishing explicit statements about the faculty as the living curriculum, faculty portraits, and a documented collegial culture would move this category toward CLASSICAL.

- Across Categories 3–5, adding explicit evidence of a documented curriculum map that shows a seamless integration of the Trivium with a historical canon (Great Books or canonical historical texts) would reinforce CLASSICAL alignment.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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